

A Farewell of Complex Emotions: Navigating Relationships and Loss

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Life often presents situations that challenge our ability to navigate and understand, especially those involving loved ones. On January 20th, I faced the heart-wrenching moment of witnessing the removal of a breathing tube from someone who had transitioned from being my romantic partner to a cherished friend due to renal failure caused by addiction. Although I did not decide to terminate her end-of-life care, I shared my ethical perspectives with her father to assist him in making a conscientious decision. This paper explores the emotional toll of such an event and the complexity of our relationship, examining the layers of love, loss, and boundaries. By reflecting on this story, I aim to provide a nuanced understanding of the ethical and emotional dimensions involved in facing such profound circumstances.

Background

Hospitalized since mid-November, my friend and former partner battled renal failure induced by years of alcoholism. Despite her academic achievements as a graduate of the Jack Welch College of Business & Technology at Sacred Heart University, her life was overshadowed by borderline personality disorder (BPD), which compounded her addiction challenges.

Our relationship, filled with affection and shared dreams, was marked by the turbulent impact of her addiction. During our time as partners, I witnessed fluctuations in her emotional state and destructive drinking patterns. This dual struggle deeply affected our relationship's dynamics.

The Development of My Ethical Framework

My ethical framework has been shaped by personal experiences and theoretical knowledge. Growing up, family teachings emphasized empathy, integrity, and responsibility. These values were later reinforced through academic exposure to ethical theories.

Deontology taught me the importance of moral duties and principles. Utilitarianism highlighted the importance of outcomes to promote the greatest good. Virtue ethics encouraged the development of moral character and virtues like patience, empathy, and resilience.

Critical Comparison of Ethical Theories. Through my journey, juxtaposing deontological ethics, utilitarianism, and virtue ethics was crucial. Deontological ethics, emphasizing duty and rules, provided a foundation for making respectful decisions but sometimes felt inadequate in complex emotional dilemmas.

In contrast, utilitarianism offered a pragmatic approach by considering the consequences of actions and striving for the greatest good. This was particularly relevant in medical care and end-of-life scenarios. Balancing the relief of her suffering with the grief of those left behind required careful consideration.

Virtue ethics complemented these frameworks by focusing on personal moral development and cultivating virtues. These virtues enabled me to maintain supportive yet healthy boundaries and foster a compassionate ethical dynamic.

The illness and hospitalization journey were a prolonged battle against relentless medical crises. Despite aggressive treatments, complications persisted and grew more severe, painting a grim picture of declining health. The decision to terminate life-extending measures was a profound ethical and personal dilemma. My friend's father, responsible for making this choice, considered various ethical principles, including my own views on quality of life. These emphasized withdrawing life-extending treatments if the quality of life became unacceptable, such as chronic coma or total dependence on others.

She lived for another 33 hours off life support before passing away. This decision reflects Collins and Kanashiro's (2022) emphasis on weighing the quality of life and the moral implications of prolonged suffering. The principles of medical ethics, including autonomy, beneficence, non-maleficence, and justice, guided this decision. Her inability to express wishes placed the decision on her father. Balancing doing good with not causing harm was essential (Beauchamp & Childress, 2019).

The Complexity of Relationships

Our relationship was affectionate but marked by emotional volatility and addiction. These tumultuous episodes necessitated a reevaluation of our relationship. Transitioning to friendship required redefining boundaries and balancing emotional support with personal well-being. The struggle with addiction often blurred the lines of dependency and exploitation. Establishing boundaries became essential for my emotional health and fostering a relationship that could withstand addiction and mental health challenges. Developing virtues like patience, empathy, and resilience was crucial in navigating this complex relationship.

The Emotional Impact

The decision to remove the breathing tube and her subsequent passing had a profound emotional impact. My initial reaction was a mix of overwhelming grief and resigned acknowledgment of the situation's inevitability. The culmination of her suffering brought relief and sorrow.

The sadness of losing a friend battled with the relief that her suffering had ended. The unresolved feelings from our romantic past intertwined with the complexities of our friendship, making it a multifaceted process of mourning and coping. The support of close friends, family, and the broader community became indispensable in this emotional labyrinth.

Analyzing my journey through Collins and Kanashiro's (2022) lens provided clarity and highlighted the importance of compassionate decision-making.

Concluding Reflections

The journey through illness and loss has profoundly influenced my understanding of relationships, boundaries, and grief. It emphasized the delicate balance necessary to support someone while preserving one's well-being. Insights from Collins and Kanashiro (2022) reinforce the critical role of ethical decision-making in personal and professional challenges.

Reflecting on this experience, I recognize the layers of resilience, compassion, and ethical considerations that defined our relationship. By sharing this story, I aim to honor the memory of my friend and provide a framework for understanding the intersection of love, loss, and ethical decision-making in human relationships.

References

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